

LEC15 - Religion

What is Religion

- Connection between the “natural” and “supernatural”
 - Provides answers to life’s problems
 - No definition, but commonly understood
 - Sociological study of beliefs, symbols, practices, and organizational forms of religions
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Religious Organization

- **Religious organizations**
 - **Church** → Bureaucratic organization with a positive state relation
 - **Ecclesia** → Formal part of the state
 - **Denomination** → Subgroup within a religion
 - **Sects**
 - **Sect** → Broken away from major religion
 - **NRM/Cult** → Small group emphasizing private personal belief
 - New religious movements mainly consist of...
 - Converts
 - Atypical segment of the population
 - Charismatic leaders
 - Young religions
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New Religious Movements

- Raelians
 - Quebec-based NRM (Claude Vorilhon)
 - Life created by aliens called Elohim
 - Benign, support equality
 - Aum Shinrikyo
 - Japan-based cult (Shoko Asahara)
 - Countercultural beliefs, controlling leaders, brainwashing, isolation from the outside world
 - Responsible for Sarin gas attacks on Tokyo subway
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Functions of Religion

- Social cohesion
 - Moral community and solidarity
 - Rules and values
- Social control
 - Conformity
 - Judgement

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- Meaning and purpose
 - Comfort and belonging
 - Major transitions
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Spirituality

- “The experience of a personal relationship with the transcendent”
 - Positive relationships related to spirituality related to spiritual beliefs and psychological well-being
 - Those reporting more spiritual experiences (ex. Finding strength in spirituality, experience a connection to all of life) report greater happiness, self-esteem, and optimism
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Day-to-day Spirituality

- If you report high baseline spirituality, on days when you feel your life is more meaningful or feel better about yourself, you will also feel more spiritual
 - Identification and commitment to a spiritual belief system on a given day provides meaning and purpose in life, which in turn increases self-esteem
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Conflict and Religion

Inequality

- Religion is a sign of the oppressed creature, the sentiment of a heartless world, and the soul of soulless conditions. It is the opium of the people
- Tool of the ruling elite
- Camouflages personal interests, strengthens authority, and justifies the political and economic status quo
- Religion justifies inequalities and interprets them as vital components of a divine plan

Social Change

- Revolution mobilized by the oppressed for revolution and social change
- Liberation theology
 - Blend of christian theology and Marxist notations of social conflict and class struggle
 - Originated in Latin America as a reaction to widespread poverty, social inequality, and political repression
 - Advocate for just societies that eliminate poverty and inequality
 - Reject the separation between spirituality and worldliness

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- Just and equal world can be crafted in the here and now
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Feminism and Religion

Gender Inequality

- Religion as a patriarchal instrument that is hostile to gender equality and an obstacle to female liberation
- Gender inequality divinely inspired, and such divine warrants for inequality have widened the existing inequalities between the sexes
- Institutionalized patriarchy and sexism

Lived Religion

- How people understand, interpret, experience, and practice religion and spirituality in their everyday lives
 - Ex. Arab Muslims and feminism
 - Not passively socialized into patriarchal interpretations of Islam
 - Personal factors like education, critical thinking, female employment
 - Structural factors like existing feminist movements, free expression, predicted deviation from patriarchal norms
 - Support is for Muslim, not secular, feminism
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Contemporary Trends in Religion

- Secularization Thesis
 - Religious institutions, actions, and consciousness are on the decline worldwide
 - Wealth influences religiosity
 - As wealth increases, religiosity decreases
 - Education influences religiosity
 - Higher education decreases religiosity
 - Age influences religiosity
 - Older people tend to be more religious
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Secularization

- Fundamentalism
 - Growth in conservative protestantism
 - Conservative reaction against globalization, modernization, geo-political circumstances
- Global populations

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- 83% of the world's population is religious (74% of Canadians)
 - By 2050, 87% of the world's population may be religious
 - However...
 - Improved existential factors like wealth and health
 - Increasing education
 - Internet
 - These factors are known to decrease religiosity
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Revised Secularization Thesis

Secular institutions break off from the institutions of religion over time. As a result, religion governs an ever-smaller part of most people's lives and has become a matter of personal choice